

Economics & Policy Workshop

Yale Pathways to Arts & Humanities Summer Scholars Program

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About This Workshop

This workshop uses real-life and policy examples to show how economics shapes the world around you — from everyday choices to climate change, global trade, and financial markets. No prior economics knowledge required.

Course Schedule

90 minutes per session

Day 1 — Economic Decision-Making & Everyday Choices

- **Concepts:** scarcity, trade-offs, opportunity cost, the sunk-cost fallacy, cost-benefit analysis
- **Activity:** Stakeholder Analysis — argue a real policy from the perspective of students, teachers, and government officials
- **Policy debate:** Should Connecticut schools ban cell phones bell-to-bell? (HB 5035)

Day 2 — Correlation vs. Causation

- **Concepts:** correlation vs. causation, confounding variables, reverse causality, causal diagrams (DAGs)
- **Puzzle:** untangle a classic confounder — why do ice cream sales and deaths rise together?
- **Activity:** Chart Detective — analyze real misleading charts, then draw the same data two ways

Day 3 — Climate Change & Common Resources

- **Concepts:** supply and demand, rivalrous and excludable goods, externalities, tragedy of the commons, government policy tools
- **Game:** Candy Commons — experience the tragedy of the commons, with and without monitoring
- **Policy debate:** Should the U.S. put a price on carbon? (a \$50/ton carbon tax)

Day 4 — Trade & Tariffs

- **Concepts:** gains from trade, absolute vs. comparative advantage, specialization, tariffs and who pays them
- **Worked example:** A Tale of Two Countries — specialize and swap to see why trade grows the pie
- **Policy debate:** Are the 2018 U.S. steel tariffs worth it? Weigh benefits and costs from real sources

Day 5 — Financial Literacy

- **Concepts:** compound interest, inflation and real vs. nominal returns, bonds and interest rates, stocks, diversification
- **Activity:** Financial Literacy Quiz — four core questions, run as a team competition with a live results reveal
- **Takeaway:** practical tools for saving, investing, and beating inflation